World Health Organization
African Region

MEC 2026 | DAY 2 | BLOCK A | POLICY BRIEF P1

# Minimum MEAL Package and maturity baseline

Paper MEC-09, policy P1 of 7, for decision

**Friday 20 November 2026, 09:05–10:05** | Block A. Know where we stand | For decision

*Draft of 4 November 2026 for TWG review. Parameters such as deadlines, response times and thresholds not set by the Framework are proposals, shown as such in the decision options.*

### The policy in brief

Every Country Office reaches and keeps the Minimum MEAL Package floor, establishes its maturity baseline through a Learning Lab by June 2028 and turns it into a costed Country MEAL Development Plan endorsed by the WR.

## Why this policy

The Minimum MEAL Package is the floor below which a Country Office cannot credibly claim that evidence informs its decisions. The Framework sets the floor at Level 3 (Developing) and builds every other instrument on it: the Country MEAL Development Plan closes gaps to the floor first, the heat map shows where support is needed, and the re-assessment tracks progress.

None of this works until each office knows where it stands. Today the Region has a measured baseline for four pilot offices only, so support cannot be targeted and development plans have no diagnosis to start from.

### What the evidence shows

- A measured MEAL maturity baseline exists in **4 of 47** Country Offices (Performance Intelligence pilots, 2026; paper MEC-08).
- Two floor disciplines are not yet visible in SAM1 2026: **1 of 1,336** P/S assessments cites an evidence source (Domain 5), and the decision log records no verification of completion, with **91 of 970** entries overdue at export (Domain 8).

## Scope

The 47 Country Offices. The six Regional Office budget centres complete the Annex C self-assessment for their own operations in 2027.

## The policy

1. **The Minimum MEAL Package is mandatory.** Every Country Office reaches at least Level 3 (Developing) against the minimum requirements of Annex C, the master reference for all twelve domains, starting with the seven essential domains summarized in Part VII.1, and keeps it. The 3% financing requirement (Domain 3) is the gateway: an office below it does not meet the Package, whatever its other results (see P3).
2. **Self-assessment by 31 March 2027.** Each office completes the Annex C self-assessment checklist, with the evidence for each requirement. MSC consolidates the results into a first regional view of the floor and uses it to schedule the Learning Labs.
3. **A maturity baseline in three waves.** Each office establishes its baseline against the four pillars, twelve domains and 48 sub-dimensions (Annex A) through a facilitated Learning Lab: wave 1 from January to June 2027, wave 2 from July to December 2027 and wave 3 from January to June 2028. MSC sets the order with the clusters, starting with offices whose self-assessment shows the largest gaps and offices preparing a new CCS. The four pilot offices confirm their 2026 baseline against the final scale in wave 1.
4. **Scores rest on evidence.** Offices score themselves against the descriptors of Annex D and MSC validates the scores for consistency across offices. A level is awarded only when its criteria are met and supported by verifiable evidence; where evidence is ambiguous, the lower level applies. Documentary evidence alone never meets a requirement (Annex C, Section C5).

5. **A development plan within eight weeks.** Within eight weeks of its validated baseline, each office prepares its Country MEAL Development Plan on the Annex B template: priority gaps, root causes, target levels, actions, owners, costs and funding sources. Closing gaps to the floor comes before any other improvement. The WR endorses the plan as a resource commitment; MSC validates it for the Region as a commitment to support (Annex B, Template Section 10).
6. **The plan lives in the workplan.** Each office enters the actions that close the gaps found in its self-assessment in its 2028–2029 workplan. The full development plan enters the SPM and the workplan once endorsed: at workplan preparation for offices assessed in wave 1, and at the first workplan revision of 2028 for waves 2 and 3. Progress is reviewed monthly in the WR-led review, against milestones each quarter, alongside each SAM cycle and in full once a year (Annex B, Section B9).
7. **Annual check, re-assessment every two years.** Package status is reviewed each year in step with the SAM cycle (Annex C, Section C11). The full maturity assessment is repeated two years after the baseline.
8. **Results direct support.** Validated scores feed the Regional Maturity Heat Map, which targets support and is never used to rank offices. An office below the floor receives targeted support and an accelerated plan.

## Who does what

| | |
|---|---|
| **WHO Representative** | Accountable for reaching and keeping the floor; endorses the development plan and chairs its monthly review. |
| **MEAL focal point** | Leads the self-assessment, assembles the evidence and coordinates the plan and its tracking. |
| **Programme leads** | Meet the floor in their areas, in particular P/S monitoring and decision follow-up. |
| **MSC Unit** | Schedules the waves, facilitates Learning Labs, validates scores and development plans, maintains the heat map and reports to the DPM and the MEC. |
| **Regional Office clusters** | Provide the support committed in validated plans; join Learning Labs in their technical areas. |

## Timeline

| When | Milestone |
|---|---|
| 20 Nov 2026 | Policy adopted by the MEC |
| 31 Mar 2027 | Annex C self-assessment completed by all 47 Country Offices |
| Jan–Jun 2027 | Wave 1 Learning Labs, including the four pilot offices |
| Jul–Dec 2027 | Wave 2 Learning Labs; first heat map at MEC 2027 |
| Jan–Jun 2028 | Wave 3 Learning Labs; all baselines validated |
| 31 Aug 2028 | All 47 development plans endorsed and in the workplans |

## How compliance is measured

| Indicator | Baseline | Target |
|---|---|---|
| Country Offices with a validated maturity baseline | 4 of 47 pilots, to be confirmed in wave 1 | 47 by 30 June 2028 |
| Country Offices with a WR-endorsed development plan in the workplan | Not yet measured | 47 by 31 August 2028 |
| Country Offices meeting the floor in every domain | First, unvalidated reading from the 2027 self-assessment | Rising at each annual review; target set by MEC 2028 from the validated baselines |

## Decision options

| Option | What the MEC would adopt | Implications |
|---|---|---|
| **A** Recommended | **Mandatory for all Country Offices in three waves, with the self-assessment by March 2027** | Every office has a validated baseline and plan by mid-2028, at a pace MSC and the facilitator pool can sustain. |
| **B** | Mandatory in two waves, with all baselines by December 2027 | All plans endorsed by early 2028, a few months sooner; facilitation needs roughly double in 2027. |
| **C** | Self-assessment only; Learning Labs on request | Lowest cost, but no validated baseline, no reliable heat map and development plans without a diagnosis. |

## Resources

Learning Lab facilitation, travel and the platform modules for the assessment and development plan. Costed in paper MEC-10.

> **The MEC is asked to**
>
> Adopt the Minimum MEAL Package as the mandatory floor for all Country Offices and the three-wave baseline schedule (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts VII, VIII and XIII; Annexes A, B, C and D; Annex G, Modules 5, 6 and 12. Domains: All twelve domains at the floor (Annex C), strengthened in the Framework's order of priority (Part XIV.2).